

I live in a fine home ... but have no mortgage. All my children's college accounts were more than fully funded before they even began attending college.

Unfortunately, Johnny's story, including his apology, will never get into syndication.

SO RARE THE JOHNNY LUCASES

Why are so few people in America affluent? Even most households with six-figure annual incomes are not affluent. These people have a different orientation than does Johnny Lucas. They believe in spending tomorrow's cash today. They are debt-prone and are on earn-and-consume treadmills. To many of them, those who do not display abundant material possessions are not successful. To them, nondisplay-oriented people like Johnny Lucas are their inferiors.

Johnny Lucas is not likely to be held in high regard by many of his neighbors. On a social status scale, he is below average. But on what criteria? In his neighbors' eyes, Johnny has low occupational status. He is an owner of a small business. What happens when he occasionally comes home in one of his janitorial vans? The van stays in his driveway until he leaves the next morning. What are his neighbors to think? They do not know that Johnny is financially independent. They don't give him points for being married and never divorced, fully funding his children's college tuition, employing several dozen people, having integrity, being frugal, paying off his mortgage, and so forth. No, many of his neighbors would prefer that Johnny move out of the neighborhood. Why? Perhaps it's because he and his family don't look affluent, dress like the affluent, drive the vehicles of the affluent, or work in high-status positions.